



Report on one Trump case to be put on hold

Special counsel's findings on handling of classified documents delayed

BY JEREMY ROEBUCK AND PERRY STEIN

The Justice Department does not plan to publicly release special counsel Jack Smith's findings on Donald Trump's alleged mishandling of classified documents until litigation against his co-defendants concludes, according to a court filing Wednesday.

But prosecutors said Attorney General Merrick Garland will make public the portion of Smith's report outlining his investigation into Trump's efforts to undo the results of the 2020 election — and to permit select members of Congress to review the withheld portion about the classified documents probe.

The report could explain the strategy the government would have employed against Trump if either case had gone to trial, as well as the full scope of the

SEE TRUMP ON A7

Supreme Court: Trump seeks to delay hush money sentencing. **A3**

Biden won't take the new rulers of Syria off terrorist list

BY JOHN HUDSON

The Biden administration has decided to maintain the terrorist designation of Syria's new Islamist rulers for the remainder of President Joe Biden's tenure, leaving a critical decision about Hay'at Tahrir al-Sham and its leader, Ahmed al-Sharaa, to the incoming Trump administration, said three U.S. officials familiar with the matter.

The terrorist designation for HTS is a key obstacle to Syria's long-term economic viability, but U.S. officials said the Islamist rebels who stunned the world late last year by overthrowing Syrian President Bashar al-Assad must demonstrate they have made a clean break with extremist groups, in particular al-Qaeda, before the label can be

SEE SYRIA ON A13

L.A. blazes unleash destruction



AP PHOTO/ETIENNE LAUREN



ETHAN SWOPE/AP



CAROLINE BREHMAN/EPA-EFE/SHUTTERSTOCK

CLOCKWISE FROM TOP: A firefighter battles flames Wednesday in Pacific Palisades, California. The remains of a house in Pacific Palisades. A fire-ravaged business in Altadena. The blazes, fueled by wind gusts topping 100 mph, have left at least five people dead.

Along Sunset Boulevard, block after block is reduced to rubble

BY BRIANNA SACKS AND BRADY DENNIS

LOS ANGELES — Home after home is gone. Old apartment buildings, mansions, cottages, generational homes. Gone. Community centers. Parks. Gas stations. Coffee shops. Banks. Grocery stores. They're all gone.

At around 10 a.m. Wednesday morning, Pacific Palisades, a coastal community of about 23,000 people, was still burning from the wildfires that have

swept through the city this week.

The town looked as if several large bombs had gone off. Flames were leaping through an apartment complex next to a retirement community, its top floors caved in. The Gelson's supermarket across the street was torched. A gas station where a Washington Post reporter stood Tuesday, talking to police about how bad this fire was getting, was also gone, the cars left in its parking lot now just shells of brown steel.

In the square, a popular com-

munity spot, the Starbucks inside the iconic light pink Bank of America building was gone. Behind it, the smoking devastation stretched for blocks.

Heavy winds rocked metal street signs like swings and caused smoldering fires to reignite in some blown-out storefronts.

Firefighting and emergency response officials have been stretched to the limit as three major fires blew up around Los Angeles, flanking much of the

region and spurring mass evacuations. On Tuesday, many Palisades residents barely made it out as flames quickly ripped through the dry, brushy hills, with winds sending embers spewing down toward the densely populated neighborhoods.

Along Sunset Boulevard, the winding two-way road that cuts through much of Los Angeles, street after street has been reduced to rubble or is still burning, glowing flames really the

SEE PALISADES ON A11

FAST SWATHS OF LAND LEFT IN ASHES

No control over flames; 'feels like Armageddon'

BY MAEVE RESTON, HOLLY BAILEY AND N. KIRKPATRICK

LOS ANGELES — Burgeoning wildfires burned uncontrollably across a wide swath of greater Los Angeles on Wednesday, transforming the landscape into scenes of apocalyptic destruction with blocks and blocks of neighborhoods reduced to ash. Authorities called the situation one of the most catastrophic fire events in California history.

Fueled by hurricane-force wind gusts upward of 100 mph, at least five fires covering tens of thousands of acres raged out of control to the west, north and northeast of downtown Los Angeles with almost zero percent containment as of late Wednesday. At least five deaths and a "high number of significant injuries" were reported, according to officials, as thousands of exhausted firefighters struggled to keep up amid continued severe weather and a diminished water supply.

At least 130,000 people across the sprawling metropolitan area were under evacuation orders, while nearly 1.5 million residents were without power. Smoke from the various blazes combined to turn the sky a dark, ominous orange; air quality ranged from unhealthy to hazardous.

More than 1,000 structures had been destroyed by late afternoon, including homes, businesses, houses of worship and neighborhood landmarks. Among the worst-hit swaths: a large part of the Pacific Palisades, an affluent, celebrity-packed neighborhood in the rolling hills of west Los Angeles overlooking the Pacific Ocean. In less than two days, the Palisades Fire had consumed nearly 16,000 acres and counting — with 10,000 acres burned since Wednesday morning alone.

"It feels like Armageddon," said Theresa Corcoran, 49, who was desperate to find out if her family home there had survived after she had evacuated to a friend's house in nearby Bel Air. "I woke up this morning and looked out, and it's dark clouds. You can't

SEE FIRES ON A10

At the smoldering scene: Black smoke, bottlenecks and chaos. **A9**

Disaster politics: Trump clashes with Newsom over wildfires. **A9**

Hollywood: Celebrities are fleeing, and events are being canceled. **C1**

In an era of cynicism, Carter believed in the idealists

As he broke with the playbook, the outsiders he brought in left their mark on Washington

BY MARC FISHER

Marcy Kaptur was on the streets of Chicago's Near Northwest section, fending off real estate developers and a mayor who aimed to raze a struggling neighborhood. Alexis Herman had been a social worker with Catholic Charities, trying to find jobs for poor people at a shipyard in Pascagoula, Mississippi.

Mary Elizabeth King was running a group designed to boost the paltry number of women in the top ranks of the federal government. And Joan Claybrook was one of Ralph Nader's Raiders, the cadre of lawyers and researchers around the country pushing for consumer protections.



ALLISON ROBERT FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Jason Painter and his 6-year-old son, Joseph, were among the many visitors as Jimmy Carter lay in state at the Capitol. Story, A6

In 1977, they and a few hundred idealistic, young, smart activists like them came to Washington to join Jimmy Carter's new administration — an injection of outsiders into a White House that took pride in breaking out from the standard D.C. playbook. Suddenly, the government was salted with battalions of aides and agency chiefs who came not from Capitol Hill jobs or lobbying firms, but from the anti-Vietnam War and civil rights movements, environmentalist and feminist groups, and an array of other nonprofits.

SEE CARTER ON A4

Funeral: Meet the people behind preparations for Carter's service. **B1**

X users say fact-check system coming to Meta can feel futile

BY TRISHA THADANI AND WILL OREMUS

Before the November election, Walt Wang said he spent 10 to 20 hours a week debunking falsehoods on X, the social media platform owned by Elon Musk. As election-related lies and propaganda spread throughout the site, he carefully crafted responses, backed by reputable sources, to counter the false claims before they reached millions of users.

But often, he said, his efforts felt "similar to a game of whack-a-mole." He spent hours debunking one conspiracy theory, only to watch another crop up moments later.

Wang is part of a legion of X

users who volunteer their time policing misinformation on the site through a feature called Community Notes, which Meta said Tuesday it will adopt in place of its extensive fact-checking program in the United States.

While dedicated contributors like Wang praise the program for giving moderation power to a diverse set of users, they warn that it's an inadequate replacement for professional fact-checking — and fear it will be even harder for everyday people to combat falsehoods on Meta's array of global platforms, including Facebook, Instagram and

SEE FACT-CHECKING ON A16

Fact or fiction? A guide to help consume information wisely. **A15**

IN THE NEWS

Pakistan-Afghanistan clashes Tensions between the two countries are rising as Islamabad accuses the Taliban regime of harboring insurgents. **A12**

Closing the budget gap Maryland Gov. Wes Moore (D) announced plans for \$2 billion in cuts, including climate programs. **B1**

THE NATION

A tentative deal has averted a strike that could have frozen East and Gulf coast ports. **A2**
The White House rejected pleas to delist the grizzly bear as a threatened species. **A7**

THE WORLD

An Italian journalist returned to Rome after being arrested in Iran last month. **A13**
Ukraine said at least 13 people died in a Russian bomb strike in the city of Zaporizhzhia. **A14**

THE ECONOMY

The IRS must prioritize identity theft cases, which are taking an average of nearly two years to resolve, a watchdog said. **A15**
Scientists have trained an AI model to predict gene activity, which could pave the way for new gene therapies. **A20**

THE REGION

The Virginia General Assembly quickly met in the capital and adjourned until Monday as Richmond's water crisis drags on. **B1**
Johns Hopkins University has settled a federal inquiry regarding antisemitic and anti-Arab complaints. **B1**

STYLE

A security contractor who is suing CNN testified that a 2021 report ruined his career by associating him with illegal activity. **C1**

LOCAL LIVING

The germiest spots in your home might not be where you think they are.

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